

Hawkins Under Siege: Stranger Things

Thomas Jefferson Model United Nations Conference

TechMUN XXXIII



High School Crisis Committee

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Esteemed Delegates,

Welcome to the Hawkins Under Siege: Stranger Things Crisis Single Delegation. We're excited for a weekend of lively debate. This committee will be centered on the two subtopics for Stranger Things, as explained below in the background guide. Delegates will collaborate to write working papers that address the issues faced during Stranger Things, including updates presented by the committee.

In regards to the types of delegates we're looking for, we want individuals who can bring creativity to the committee and make a strong impact, both in their speeches and in their backroom. Leadership matters, but we are looking for leaders who focus on collaboration and can uniquely bend others' ideas together. Please take this conference as an opportunity to think big - we are looking for unconventional approaches to large issues that highlight efficiency and practicality. Don't be afraid to take calculated risks and explore new approaches. Lastly, no forms of harassment, bullying, or plagiarism will be tolerated.

No matter your background or experience level, our goal is to make sure TechMUN XXXIII is a conference you'll remember. If you have any questions don't hesitate to contact us at strangerthingstechmun@gmail.com. Let's make this conference a memorable experience filled with teamwork and fun!

Best regards,

Avni Patel and Pranav Kalidindi

Crisis Hawkins Under Siege: Stranger Things

Introduction to Stranger Things

Stranger Things, created by the Duffer Brothers and released by Netflix on July 15, 2016, is a critically acclaimed science fiction television series that blends supernatural horror with 1980s nostalgia. Set in the fictional town of Hawkins, Indiana, the series initially follows the mysterious disappearance of a young boy, Will Byers, and the emergence of a secretive government experiment connected to an alternate dimension known as the Upside Down. Praised for its compelling storytelling, character-driven narrative, and retro aesthetic, Stranger Things quickly became a cultural phenomenon, drawing inspiration from Cold War paranoia, classic horror films, and the growing mistrust of government secrecy during the late 20th century. Its mix of small-town innocence and unseen danger captivated audiences worldwide, cementing its place as one of Netflix's most influential original productions.

As the series progresses, Hawkins is revealed to be the site of covert experimentation conducted by Hawkins National Laboratory, a government facility operating under the U.S. Department of Energy. These experiments, primarily involving a young girl known as Eleven, inadvertently opened a gateway to the Upside Down—a parallel dimension inhabited by hostile creatures such as the Demogorgon and the Mind Flayer. The consequences of these actions escalate rapidly, endangering civilians, destabilizing the town, and placing children at the center of an unfolding crisis. Despite repeated warnings and mounting evidence of supernatural threats, government officials attempt to contain the situation through secrecy, misinformation, and force, often prioritizing national security and reputation over public safety.

By the later seasons, the crisis in Hawkins intensifies, as the Upside Down begins to merge with the real world, causing mass casualties, widespread panic, and irreversible damage to the town's infrastructure and population. The failures of leadership, ethical violations in

scientific research, and lack of transparency allow the threat to grow unchecked. Ultimately, *Stranger Things* serves as a cautionary tale about the dangers of unchecked ambition, abuse of power, and the human cost of secrecy. While fictional, the series reflects real-world concerns surrounding government accountability, experimental ethics, and crisis management, making it a compelling framework for debate. Its enduring popularity underscores its central message: that ignorance, denial, and hubris can turn controllable risks into catastrophic consequences.



Topic A: Investigating the Upside Down

Background:

The Upside Down was initially perceived as a controlled and isolated anomaly, believed by scientists at Hawkins National Laboratory to be a dimension that could be observed, contained, and exploited through advanced experimentation. This assumption fostered dangerous overconfidence in human understanding of interdimensional science. While researchers identified surface-level characteristics—such as its toxic atmosphere, distorted terrain, and predatory organisms—the true nature of the Upside Down remained largely unknown. Critical variables, including its origin, ecological structure, temporal mechanics, and level of sentient control, were ignored or underestimated. As a result, the lack of comprehensive research protocols and ethical safeguards left officials unprepared for escalation. When the Upside Down began exerting influence over Hawkins, the absence of contingency planning and the dismissal of scientific uncertainty contributed directly to the rapid spread of chaos and loss of life.

Current Situation:

The current status of the Upside Down is chaotic. On the one hand, government officials are sending in researchers in hazmat suits to investigate the Upside Down. The staff at the laboratory was not expecting the creation of the Upside Down, and do not know the chemical makeup and cause of the biological anomalies in the Upside Down. Meanwhile, the civilian team consisting of Eleven and her friends have applied understandings of science and observation to reach much farther conclusions than government officials have. Although surveillance teams and scientific personnel are actively observing known portals, critical investigative tools remain inadequate. Data collection is fragmented, long-term exposure effects are poorly documented, and communication between agencies is restricted by secrecy and compartmentalization.

Officials continue to operate under the assumption that catastrophic escalation is unlikely, resulting in delayed responses and minimal emergency preparedness. Furthermore, while containment protocols exist, their structural and scientific limitations are not fully understood. Should the Upside Down expand or adapt beyond current models, existing safeguards may prove insufficient, leaving Hawkins—and potentially the wider world—dangerously exposed.

Possible Solutions:

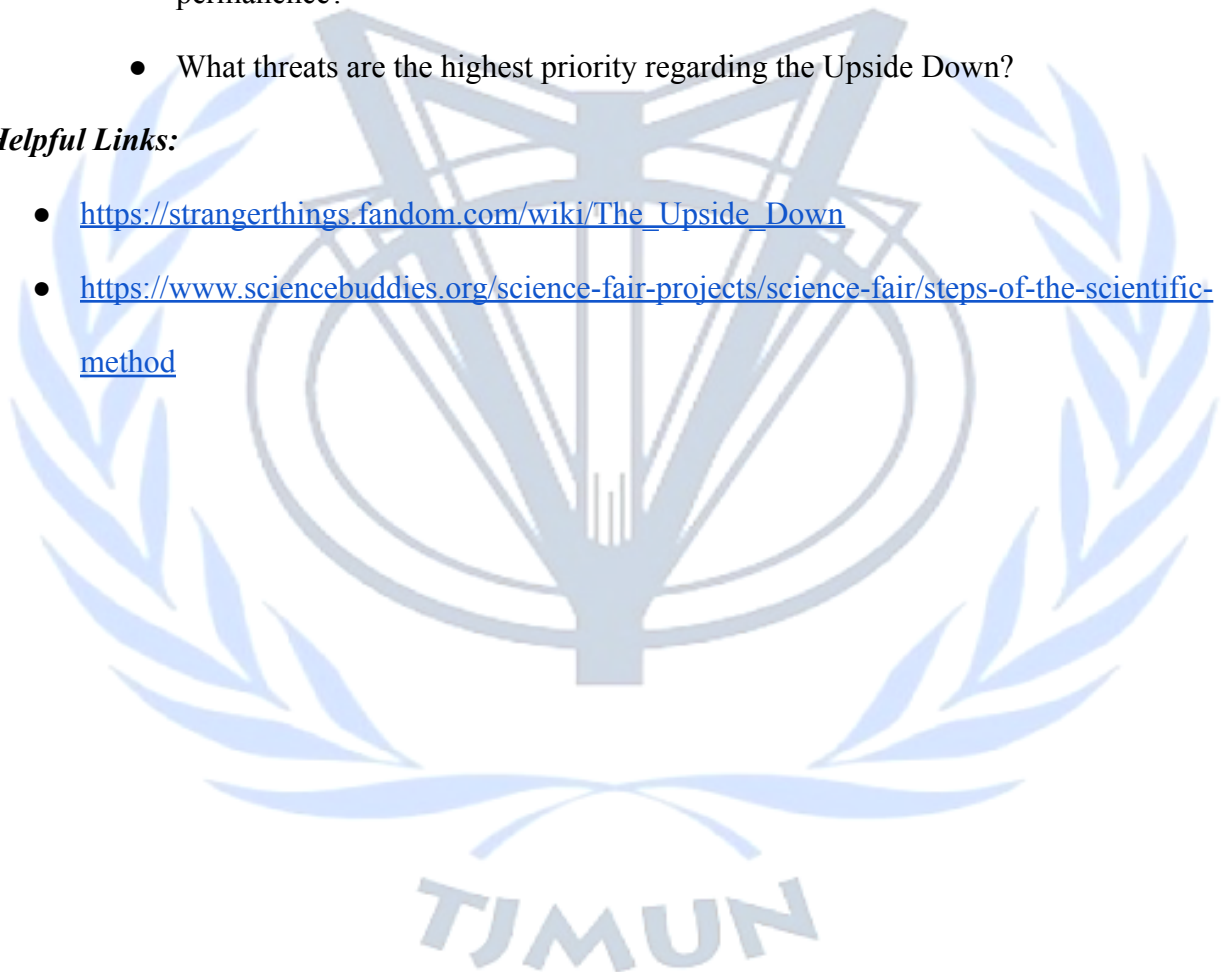
To prevent further catastrophe, multiple weaknesses in the investigation and containment of the Upside Down must be addressed. Scientific teams and government officials remain insufficiently prepared to respond to rapid interdimensional escalation, resulting in delayed decisions and fragmented responses when breaches occur. In scenarios where swift analysis and coordinated action are essential, the absence of unified investigative leadership has contributed to confusion, misinterpretation of data, and loss of control over evolving threats. Communication protocols between research divisions, military units, and local authorities require urgent reassessment to ensure timely information sharing and effective crisis response. In addition, investigative methodologies surrounding the Upside Down must be significantly improved. Current monitoring systems fail to provide comprehensive visibility into its terrain, biological hierarchy, and expansion patterns, limiting early threat detection. Environmental distortions, electromagnetic interference, and unstable portals further obstruct accurate observation, leaving researchers effectively blind to emerging dangers. A reevaluation of containment infrastructure and emergency safeguards is also necessary, particularly regarding portal stabilization, civilian evacuation readiness, and exposure mitigation. Without strengthened investigative tools, contingency planning, and ethical oversight, continued exploration of the Upside Down risks escalating an already volatile situation into an irreversible disaster.

Questions to Consider:

- How can we determine the cause of creation of the Upside Down?
- What can researchers do to better understand the Upside Down?
- How can you use your skills to address the unknowns of the Upside Down?
- How can we gain more evidence about the Upside Down, its cause, and its permanence?
- What threats are the highest priority regarding the Upside Down?

Helpful Links:

- https://strangerthings.fandom.com/wiki/The_Upside_Down
- <https://www.sciencebuddies.org/science-fair-projects/science-fair/steps-of-the-scientific-method>



Topic B: Destroying Demogorgons and Ensuring Civilian Safety

Background:

The threat posed by Demogorgons is more than a supernatural phenomenon; it reflects systemic failures in prioritizing civilian safety over secrecy and control. Presented as a contained national security issue, the government's response emphasized concealment and experimental force rather than public protection. Advanced weapons and surveillance technologies were developed to neutralize the threat, while the residents of Hawkins—particularly children and other vulnerable populations—remained uninformed and exposed. This carefully managed image of control came at the expense of safety and preparedness. When Demogorgons breached containment and attacked civilians, these disparities became undeniable, revealing the consequences of delayed action, flawed threat assessment, and a failure to place human lives above strategic ambition. It is important to note how little the residents of Hawkins know about the Upside Down, and Demagorgons may not be the only threat to citizens.

Current Situation:

As the situation in Hawkins continues to escalate, disparities in protection and preparedness remain increasingly evident. Government and military personnel operate with access to advanced weapons and intelligence, while civilians remain largely uninformed and defenseless against emerging threats. In the event of a large-scale breach, this imbalance poses a serious risk, as residents may lack the knowledge or resources necessary to evacuate or defend themselves. Existing defensive measures are insufficient to ensure the safety of the entire population, and response capabilities are limited by secrecy and delayed authorization. Meanwhile, officials continue to project an image of control, assuring the public that the situation is contained.

However, should hostile entities overwhelm current defenses, the failure to prioritize citizen safety over secrecy and reputation could result in severe consequences.

Possible Solutions:

To ensure civilian safety and restore public trust, immediate and decisive action must be taken. Communication between government agencies, military units, and local authorities should be strengthened to allow civilians timely access to accurate threat information and evacuation guidance. Defensive and offensive protocols must be reassessed to prioritize the protection of populated areas, ensuring that all residents—regardless of age or status—receive equal consideration in security planning. Additionally, authorities should implement transparent and coordinated threat-elimination strategies, focusing on the swift neutralization of Demogorgans rather than continued secrecy. By addressing these issues proactively, both public safety and institutional credibility can be preserved, preventing further loss of life and the escalation of an already volatile threat.

Questions to Consider:

- What methods can we employ to kill Demagorgans efficiently?
- How can we train Hawkins residents to combat these threats?
- Investigate the portals; is there a way to close them off and isolate ourselves from the Upside Down?
- How can we identify further threats? Is there a bigger threat than solely Demagorgans?

Helpful Links:

- https://www.jcs.mil/Portals/36/NMS%202022%20_%20Signed.pdf

- https://strangerthings.fandom.com/wiki/The_Demogorgon#:~:text=The%20Demogorgon%2C%20a%20predatory%20creature,transdimensional%20contact%20with%20the%20Demogorgon.



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Dossier

Will Byers

Will Byers was abducted at age twelve into the Upside Down, where he became psychically tethered to Vecna and used as a conduit for his power. Though rescued, Will remains emotionally fragile and uniquely sensitive to supernatural disturbances. His trauma grants him insight others lack, making him both a strategic asset and a liability. Will's loyalty to his friends is absolute, but his fear of becoming a weapon again drives many of his decisions.

Dustin Henderson

Dustin Henderson is an intelligent, scientifically curious optimist who often bridges the gap between adults and children, with vast knowledge of physics and technology. His technical knowledge, communication skills, and emotional intelligence make him a natural mediator. Dustin tends to underestimate danger, but his creativity and morale-boosting presence frequently alter the course of crises.

Michael Wheeler

Mike Wheeler is the de facto leader of the original group of friends. Highly loyal and emotionally driven, Mike often prioritizes personal relationships over logic. His close bond with Eleven and Will places him at the emotional center of supernatural conflicts, making him influential but prone to rash decisions under pressure. He is a great friend, good at teamwork and collaboration, and full of heart and passion.

Lucas Sinclair

Lucas Sinclair is pragmatic, skeptical, and tactically minded. Unlike his peers, he questions authority figures and supernatural explanations until proven. Lucas often serves as the group's

realist, willing to make hard decisions others avoid. His internal conflicts, especially regarding Max, can affect his judgment during crises. Overall, he is the most practical of the group, always posing logistical questions and working out the details.

Max Mayfield

Max Mayfield is fiercely independent and emotionally guarded, shaped by family trauma and exposure to violence. She becomes a primary target of Vecna due to her unresolved grief, yet her resilience and self-awareness allow her to resist longer than others. Max represents both vulnerability and defiance in the face of psychological warfare. She is strong and decisive, with an attitude of perseverance and bravery.

Nancy Wheeler

Nancy Wheeler is investigative, driven, and increasingly fearless. Initially motivated by guilt and curiosity, she evolves into a determined truth-seeker willing to confront both monsters and human institutions. Her journalistic instincts make her a key exposé of secrets, and she often pushes crises into the public sphere. She is resilient, never taking no for an answer, and not afraid of any challenge or obstacle that stands in her way.

Holly Wheeler

As a symbol of normalcy and innocence, her well-being influences the emotional stability of the Wheeler family. She is clever and a good leader, able to win over the trust of her peers and make friends easily. She has good intuition and a strong sense of self.

Steve Harrington

Steve Harrington has evolved from an egocentric teenager into a fiercely protective frontline combatant. Though lacking supernatural abilities or academic expertise, Steve compensates with physical bravery, adaptability, and an unwavering willingness to sacrifice himself for others.

Often considered the “Dad” of the group, his leadership in combat situations and mentorship of younger members make him indispensable. However, his tendency to rush into danger without planning places him at constant risk.

Robin Buckley

Robin Buckley is intellectually sharp, socially perceptive, and strategically valuable due to her linguistic skills and deductive reasoning. She plays a critical role in decoding enemy communications and uncovering hidden structures behind supernatural operations. While outwardly confident and sarcastic, Robin experiences anxiety that can surface during high-pressure moments, though it rarely impairs her effectiveness. She is a trustworthy friend, who characters often turn to in times of trouble or with serious concerns.

Jonathon Byers

Jonathan Byers is observant, introverted, and deeply shaped by responsibility beyond his years. Acting as a surrogate protector for Will and Joyce, Jonathan prioritizes family stability over personal ambition. His emotional distance and avoidance behaviors may hinder rapid decision-making, but his loyalty and situational awareness make him a stabilizing presence during prolonged crises.

Jim Hopper

Jim Hopper is a hardened law enforcement officer with extensive experience confronting both institutional corruption and supernatural threats. His parental bond with Eleven is a defining motivator, often overriding protocol and self-preservation. Hopper’s decisiveness and combat experience are invaluable, though his inclination toward unilateral action can complicate coordination with allies. He is often blunt and commanding, but extremely resourceful and clever, finding a way out of any improbable situation.

Joyce Byers

Joyce Byers is driven by intuition, maternal instinct, and a refusal to accept official narratives when they conflict with lived reality. Though not physically imposing, her persistence and emotional clarity frequently expose truths others dismiss. Joyce thrives in chaos but struggles with prolonged uncertainty, making her relentless but emotionally vulnerable.

Karen Wheeler

Karen Wheeler represents the suburban status quo of Hawkins. Although initially removed from the town's darker realities, she becomes increasingly perceptive. While not directly involved in operations, her growing awareness positions her as a potential bridge between secrecy and exposure. If fully informed, Karen could either become a powerful ally or an uncontrollable risk.

Murray Bauman

Murray Bauman is a conspiracy theorist turned validated investigator whose paranoia is matched only by his accuracy. Highly suspicious of authority, Murray excels at uncovering hidden agendas and foreign involvement. His abrasive personality and lack of discretion make him difficult to manage, but his intelligence and fearlessness are undeniable assets.

Vickie Dunne

Vickie Dunne is largely removed from the supernatural conflict but represents normalcy within the social sphere of Hawkins High. Her growing connection to Robin makes her a potential emotional liability if exposed to danger. While not a strategic player, her presence influences Robin's priorities and risk tolerance.

Mr. Clarke

Mr. Clarke is a science teacher whose intellectual guidance unknowingly equips students to survive extraordinary threats. Though unaware of the full extent of the supernatural, his emphasis

on curiosity and critical thinking indirectly strengthens the group's problem-solving capacity. If briefed, he could become a significant analytical asset. However, exposure poses ethical and safety concerns.

Derek Turnbow

Derek Turnbow is an aggressive, volatile individual whose actions are driven by insecurity and the desire for dominance. While not inherently aligned with supernatural forces, his recklessness and susceptibility to manipulation make him a potential destabilizing factor. In a crisis scenario, Derek is more likely to escalate conflict than resolve it.

Erika Sinclair

Erika Sinclair is sharp-tongued, highly intelligent, and surprisingly resourceful. Though younger than most operatives, her confidence, skepticism, and logistical skills allow her to operate effectively in hostile environments. Erika's lack of fear and strong self-interest can be both an advantage and a risk, depending on incentives.

Ted Wheeler

Ted Wheeler is largely disengaged from both family and community crises, preferring denial and passivity. While not a direct threat, his inaction contributes to institutional blindness within Hawkins. Ted's refusal to question authority makes him emblematic of the town's failure to recognize escalating danger.

Argyle

Argyle is laid-back, empathetic, and deeply loyal despite his lack of awareness regarding the full scope of supernatural threats. His calm demeanor provides emotional grounding for others, particularly Jonathan. Though not strategically trained, Argyle's reliability under stress makes him a useful support asset.

Billie

Billy Hargrove is aggressive, volatile, and deeply traumatized, making him vulnerable to possession by the Mind Flayer. While initially a significant threat, Billy's final act of resistance demonstrates that emotional bonds can disrupt even the strongest external control. His trajectory serves as a warning regarding unchecked trauma and manipulation.

Eddie

Eddie Munson is a charismatic outsider whose defiance of social norms makes him both a scapegoat and a symbol. Though initially fearful, Eddie proves capable of extraordinary courage when protecting others. His death solidifies him as a martyr figure, with lasting implications for public perception and morale.

Suzie

Suzie Bingham is intellectually gifted and technologically proficient, operating remotely from Utah. Her long-distance support proves critical in high-stakes situations, though her insistence on emotional validation during crises can delay action. Despite this, her loyalty to Dustin ensures continued cooperation.

Chrissy Cunningham

Chrissy Cunningham is a compassionate individual suffering from severe psychological distress and self-loathing, making her an ideal target for Vecna. Her death underscores the consequences of unaddressed trauma and the dangers of isolation. Chrissy represents the civilian cost of the supernatural conflict.